RE: Question on the academic rigour and difficulty of your Biological Sciences Bsc

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From: Aryan Thanki aryanthanki313@hotmail.com
To: bioadmissions@herts.ac.uk
Date: Tue, 22 Oct 2024, 11:19

Hello

Hope you are well

I am enquiring as to the academic rigour associated with your BSc Biological Sciences degree program. For this degree, you typically ask for grades B to C in Science A Levels.

So, therefore, candidates will usually be entering with combinations of grades B and C in A Level Biology and Chemistry.

Does this mean the program is tailored to the academic level and ability of the students taking this course- in that because you ask for B and C grades, you only need to be at that level to do the course successfully. You will not need to be working at an A* level in Biology or Chemistry to access the course or access the content or access the examination questions.

I hope you can provide a detailed answer to my query

Many thanks

Aryan

Sent from Outlook for iOS

From: bioadmissions bioadmissions@herts.ac.uk
To: Aryan Thanki aryanthanki313@hotmail.com
Date: Tue, 22 Oct 2024, 14:16

Dear Aryan,

Thank you for your interest in the School of Life and Medical Sciences at the University of Hertfordshire.
Our courses don’t have different levels as you might find in secondary school. We accept a minimum A level of BTEC grade that will ensure that students have the knowledge base necessary to follow the content of our courses. The individual achievements are classified according to the marks in the assessments, that will determine whether a student has a first class honours, or second upper or lower or a pass.
There is an increase in complexity throughout the degree, starting from fundamental understanding at Level 4 and developing towards more specialised, detailed and complex content in Level 6, which is complemented with a research project.

I hope this helps, if you need any further information, don’t hesitate to get in touch.
Best wishes,
Alena

From: Aryan Thanki aryanthanki313@hotmail.com
To: bioadmissions bioadmissions@herts.ac.uk
Date: Tue, 22 Oct 2024, 16:14

Hello

However, to follow on from my previous question, you do **not need to working at the level of an A* student to follow and do well in your course.** Given that you've already said a B or C is what you need to follow the course content.

However the entry grades asked for at other universities are much higher:

For universities such as:

Kings College London
UCL
Imperial
Oxford and Cambridge

These all ask for an A* for their biological science degrees as a bare minimum- which as you can see and know already is a very high level of baseline proficiency to start with.

Cambridge asks for A*A*A for their BSc Biology, Oxford is A*A*A* with over 70 percent of their admitted applicants having A*A*A* at A level Biology and Chemistry or higher, which clearly is a very high calibre of students being admitted.

And I have asked these universities too as to exactly **why they ask for such high level proficiency-** it is because the content of their courses is tailored to the level of understanding of an A* level student. Cambridge says it only admits such high performing students because only these really high-end students can cope with and understand the level of academic complexity and demand of their biology degree. That's what their Biological Sciences admissions tutor told me.

So do I need to be working at the level of an A* student, or score in the top 6-4 percent of the country in A Level biology and chemistry exams to understand and follow your course content? Given you ask for B and C grades for admission not A*'s.

Thanks

Aryan

Sent from Outlook for iOS

From: bioadmissions bioadmissions@herts.ac.uk
To: Aryan Thanki aryanthanki313@hotmail.com
Date: Thu, 24 Oct 2024, 10:02

Dear Aryan,

Your findings are correct in the sense that top universities require top grades in order to accept students into their cohorts, whereas smaller universities with perhaps not such a long and outstanding reputation are less stringent in their entry requirements.

While I can't vouch for other institutions, I have taught in Cambridge and I can confirm that the level of the teaching at UH is very similar. Where there is a clear difference is in the performance and outcome of the courses, which is higher in Cambridge courses. At UH, we strive to support our students to acquire the necessary knowledge and fulfil their potential to achieve at a high level. This is demonstrated by the fact that groups of students within our cohorts do fantastically well and the levels of their degree is at par with those from top institutions.

So to answer your question, it is not that at UH we demand less, but rather that we offer an opportunity to a diversity of students to attend university and invest the effort and work to achieve a high level of understanding.

I hope this helps, best wishes,
Alena

From: Aryan Thanki aryanthanki313@hotmail.com
To: bioadmissions bioadmissions@herts.ac.uk
Date: Thu, 24 Oct 2024, 13:24

Hello

The below email is more pertinent to my query as it concerns a more relevant point:

I quote from the first email you sent me:

> We accept a minimum A level of BTEC grade that will ensure that students have the knowledge base necessary to follow the content of our courses

The minimum a level grade you accept is around a B or a C, and going by the above statement you made, students with these grades have the knowledge base necessary to follow the content of your courses. This indicates that you have ensured that, by setting the requirement of grades to a B/C, this ensures the entering students have the knowledge base to follow the course content.

Further to our correspondence:

I have spoken with UH lecturers in the department of Sports Science and they told me two things:

In response to my question “do you need to be working at the level of an a* student in Biology” **they answered no, you do not, or we would ask from them in our entry requirements. We ask for a B. Not an A*, and that is for a reason.**

This clearly evidences transparency. Because the implication is what a UH course asks for, you need.

They told me that the entry requirements of BBC for their sports science degree is evidence backed- grades at this specific intermediate level give students the best chance of doing well on their courses. In other words they are saying that you can do well on the course with a B or a C. They have made it clear that you don’t need an A* to follow their course content.

This is via correspondence I have received from one of the senior lecturers working in the department of Sports Science.

I hope to hear from you soon

Thank you

Aryan

Sent from Outlook for iOS

From: bioadmissions bioadmissions@herts.ac.uk
To: Aryan Thanki aryanthanki313@hotmail.com
Date: Thu, 31 Oct 2024, 08:56

Dear Aryan,

I am not sure I understand the motivation of your questions.
The information you received is correct regarding the entry requirements into our courses, with the level of knowledge and understanding they reflect. So if you are interested in applying to come to study with us, I would encourage you to do that.
As I explained in my previous correspondence, we make an effort to bring everyone to the same level and student performance is individual as you would expect at university level, because work includes independent study. Students can do very well independent of the grades they came in with and indeed in every cohort we have talented students who graduate with a first. So if your concern is the level of the degree you can obtain at Herts, do not worry, with our support and your hard work you can go as far as you like.

I hope this answers your queries.

Best wishes,
Alena

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6 Emails